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Delineating Eco-Epistemic Paradigms: A Multifaceted Exegesis of Environmental Morality and Hegemonic Dynamics in *Mandaar* and *Macbeth*

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Abstract

The present study will delve into the intricate political milieu of 1970s West Bengal, characterized by a confluence of socio-political factors and the ensuing ramifications of rapid industrialization, environmental degradation, and the displacement of local communities. In the process it will scrutinize the transformation of William Shakespeare's seminal work, Macbeth, into Anirban Bhattacharya's Bengali web series, Mandaar. The study places a laser focus on the artistic portrayal of Geilpur's fishermen, masterfully crafted as formidable characters such as Dablu Bhai and Mandaar within the web series. Geilpur, a fictitious fishing settlement, serves as a poignant emblem of the manifold challenges confronting the southern precincts of West Bengal in the wake of industrialization-induced dislocation of traditional livelihoods and habitats. Through the discerning lens of eco-critical analysis, this scholarly examination will meticulously delineate the intricacies of power dynamics deeply entrenched within Geilpur's socio-political fabric. These intricate dynamics are deftly juxtaposed with the socio-ecological backdrop of 11th-century Scotland. This critical inquiry will attempt to elucidate the symbiotic relationship between political hegemony, environmental degradation, and the nuanced discourse of social equity, with a pronounced emphasis on the disproportionate impact on marginalized communities. Furthermore, the research will methodically probe the tactical deployment of resource allocation as a mechanism of control and dominance.

Keywords: Eco-Criticism, Marginalization, Power dynamics, Environmental ramifications, Resource manipulation

Introduction

The undeniable importance of nature as a dominant force in all aspects of life and knowledge, regardless of differences, cannot be underestimated. Humans and nature coexist, sharing the responsibility of sustaining and conserving the world. In the context of our examination, when industrialization endeavors to assert dominance, establish control, and commodify nature, it triggers a profound conflict that reverberates through the intricate socio-environmental fabric. This conflict, in turn, yields detrimental repercussions that ripple across the broader ecological landscape. As our study unfolds amidst the complex socio-political terrain of 1970s West Bengal and its subsequent transformation, it underscores the imperative of acknowledging and addressing these foundational tensions to preserve a harmonious socio-ecological equilibrium. The lens of eco-critical analysis, which we wield in this scholarly exploration, brings into sharp relief the dynamic and multifaceted facets of the natural world. These facets, inherent in the artistic portrayal of Geilpur's fishermen in *Mandaar*, serve as a compelling force for rejuvenation, not only within the narrative itself but in the larger context of societal and environmental dynamics. Ecocriticism investigates the interconnectedness between political power dynamics and social justice issues. It recognizes that environmental degradation often has a disproportionate impact on marginalized communities, including low-income neighborhoods and indigenous peoples. When political decisions prioritize economic growth at the expense of environmental and social justice concerns, these inequalities can be exacerbated.

The historical context of Scotland's political power struggles in the eleventh century provides an example of how such dynamics can unfold. The competition for control among different clans and kings may have led to the exploitation of land and resources, such as water and timber, for military purposes. This could have resulted in deforestation, soil erosion, and water pollution,

ultimately causing long-lasting ecological consequences. Moreover, the distribution of resources could have been manipulated as a means of exerting authority and control over specific individuals or groups. Some clans may have had easier access to productive land or fishing grounds, while others were left with less fruitful regions. This pattern of unequal resource allocation could have perpetuated social and economic inequity. The close relationship between environmental issues and social and economic disparities highlights the ongoing challenges faced by marginalized communities. Ecocriticism seeks to shed light on these relationships and foster a deeper understanding of how political power dynamics can influence environmental outcomes and social justice.

Macbeth and Mandaar: Comparative Ecocritical Analysis

William Shakespeare's *Macbeth* is a seminal work in which eco-criticism unveils profound ecological insights through its intricate use of natural imagery. For instance, the repeated references to "unnatural" occurrences in the play signify the disruption of the natural order. As Patricia Parker contends in her essay, "Macbeth and the Matter of Scotland," these references reveal the moral and ecological consequences of Macbeth's actions, underscoring how the environmental degradation mirrors the moral decay within the characters¹ (Parker, 2004).

Additionally, the play's portrayal of the witches and their ability to manipulate nature underscores the connection between human ambition and ecological consequences. In his article, "Supernatural Shakespeare," Bruce R. Smith discusses how the witches' incantations evoke images of dark, supernatural forces disrupting the natural world, highlighting the eco-critical theme of the interdependence of human actions and environmental health² (Smith, 2009). Furthermore, *Macbeth* addresses unchecked ambition and its ecological ramifications, a theme explored by Terry Gifford in his work, *Pastoral*. Gifford argues that the play reflects how the

unbridled pursuit of power disregards environmental costs, echoing the moral decay within the characters and emphasizing the eco-critical perspective of the inextricable link between human and natural worlds³ (Gifford, 1999). In *Macbeth*, eco-criticism uncovers the intricate web of connections between human ambition, ecological disruption, and moral decay, ultimately emphasizing the profound link between the human and natural realms.

Anirban Bhattacharyaa's *Mandaar* ventures into the contemporary socio-environmental landscape of West Bengal, providing fertile ground for eco-critical exploration. The series poignantly portrays the exploitation of natural resources, particularly fisheries, and its repercussions on both local communities and the environment. An eco-critical lens reveals the power dynamics woven into Geilpur's socio-political fabric. For instance, the character Dablu Bhai epitomizes the unchecked exploitation of natural resources, paralleling the broader ecological degradation in the region⁴ (Bhattacharya, 2021, Episode 1). Drawing from the eco-critical insights of Timothy Morton, we can assert that Dablu Bhai's actions in *Mandaar* exemplify the concept of "dark ecology," wherein the consequences of environmental degradation are not fully realized until they have dire impacts on human and non-human entities⁵ (Morton, 2010). Moreover, *Mandaar* draws a parallel between the contemporary situation and the historical ecological challenges faced by 11th-century Scotland, emphasizing the universal nature of eco-critical concerns⁶ (Bhattacharya, 2021, Episode 1). As Laura Dassow Walls explores in her book, *The Passage to Cosmos*, the interconnectedness of human actions and ecological consequences transcends time and culture, echoing the eco-critical theme that different cultural contexts can influence the dynamics of power and their impact on the environment⁷ (Walls, 2009). In essence, *Mandaar* serves as a contemporary echo of eco-critical themes, urging viewers to contemplate the ethical and environmental dimensions of their choices

in the modern world. Like *Macbeth*, *Mandaar* compels us to consider the consequences of unchecked ambition and exploitation, both for society and the natural world, as scholars like Rob Nixon have highlighted in their work on environmental justice⁸ (Nixon, 2011).

In this comprehensive analysis, eco-criticism reveals how "Mandaar" engages with pressing ecological concerns, emphasizing the intricate interplay between human actions, power dynamics, and environmental well-being.

Overfishing and Environmental Depletion

One of the central themes in both *Macbeth* and its adaptation *Mandaar* is the unchecked exploitation of natural resources, particularly the rampant overfishing depicted in the latter. This theme underscores the ecological repercussions of human greed and short-term gain, echoing the real-world challenges of overfishing along West Bengal's extensive coastline. In *Mandaar*, the character Dablu Bhai embodies the ruthless exploitation of the ocean's resources, particularly the fish populations in the fictitious village of Geilpur. His character serves as a microcosm of the broader issue of overfishing in West Bengal. The narrative vividly portrays how years of unchecked overfishing have led to the depletion of fish populations, mirroring the grim reality of West Bengal's marine fishery resources, which are overexploited and heavily exploited. This stark exploitation has disrupted the delicate ecological balance, with consequences that extend far beyond the depletion of fish stocks. The impact of overfishing extends to the entire ecosystem. In *Mandaar*, the consequences of depleted fish populations ripple through the narrative, affecting not only the livelihoods of the fishermen but also the well-being of the ecosystem. The absence of fish disrupts the food chain, leading to imbalances in the marine ecosystem. Such imbalances can trigger the decline of other species, affecting biodiversity and ecological stability. Moreover, the overfishing theme in *Mandaar* underscores the ethical

dilemma of prioritizing short-term economic gain over long-term sustainability. The characters, driven by personal interests and political ambitions, exemplify how human actions can lead to environmental degradation. This ethical dimension resonates with the broader discourse on responsible resource management and the need for sustainable fishing practices in West Bengal. The theme of overfishing in *Mandaar* and its mirroring in *Macbeth* highlights the urgent need for responsible resource management and the preservation of marine ecosystems. Both literary works serve as cautionary tales, reminding us of the devastating consequences of environmental exploitation and the importance of ethical and sustainable practices in safeguarding our natural world.

Environmental Ethics and Exploitation

The theme of exploitation in *Macbeth* and its adaptation *Mandaar* delves into the intricate realm of environmental ethics, compelling readers and viewers to confront complex moral questions regarding humanity's relationship with the environment. In *Macbeth*, the characters' relentless pursuit of power, often at the expense of the environment, raises profound ethical inquiries. The play vividly portrays how human ambition, when allowed to run unchecked, can lead to environmental degradation and the compromise of ethical principles for personal gain. Macbeth's insatiable lust for power drives him to disrupt the natural order, symbolized by the disruption of the ecosystem through acts like the murder of King Duncan. This ethical dilemma underscores the moral costs associated with the exploitation of nature for personal ambitions.

Mandaar similarly delves into the ethical dilemmas surrounding environmental exploitation, particularly through the character Dablu Bhai. His actions, driven by personal gain and political aspirations, exemplify the moral quandaries linked to prioritizing short-term economic benefits over long-term ecological well-being. His ruthless exploitation of the ocean's resources,

particularly overfishing, reflects real-world scenarios where individuals and corporations prioritize profit over environmental responsibility.

These narratives function as potent eco-critical commentaries, inviting readers and viewers to engage in profound reflection on the ethical dimensions of environmental degradation. They compel us to ponder questions regarding our moral responsibilities toward the environment and future generations. Is it ethically justifiable to sacrifice the well-being of the ecosystem for personal gain or political power? What ethical principles should guide our interactions with nature, and how can we strike a balance between human needs and environmental preservation? The theme of exploitation in *Mandaar* and its resonance in *Macbeth* underscores the critical necessity of ethical considerations in environmental decision-making. It emphasizes the significance of integrating environmental ethics into our socio-political discourse, advocating for responsible stewardship of the environment. These literary works serve as cautionary tales, reminding us that our actions have ethical consequences and that our relationship with nature must be guided by principles of sustainability, responsibility, and profound respect for the natural world.

Resource Allocation and Power Dynamics

The theme of resource allocation as a mechanism of control and dominance, unearthed through eco-criticism in both *Mandaar* and *Macbeth*, offers a profound lens through which to examine the intricate interplay between power dynamics and environmental exploitation.

In *Mandaar*, the character of Dablu Bhai emerges as a quintessential embodiment of this manipulative resource allocation. His calculated endeavors to gain control over vital resources, encompassing embankments, estuaries, and exclusive fishing rights, serve as a microcosm of

broader socio-political dynamics at play. His unchecked power and monopoly over these resources wield a dual impact - they not only lead to the evident degradation of the environment but also serve as instruments for him to establish a tyrannical dominion over the local community. This astute manipulation of resource allocation mirrors the age-old practice of those in positions of power exploiting the distribution of resources to fortify their control. The consequences of this resource exploitation extend far beyond environmental degradation; they exacerbate preexisting inequalities, pushing already marginalized communities deeper into disenfranchisement and poverty⁹ (Bhattacharya, 2021, Episode 1).

In *Macbeth*, the concept of resource allocation takes on a different but equally potent dimension. The characters in power, like Macbeth and Lady Macbeth, recognize that control over land, castles, and noble titles provides not only material wealth but also a vehicle for political dominance. These resources are not merely tokens of affluence; they represent the levers of authority that can manipulate the political landscape itself. Characters possessing these resources can exert considerable influence over the socio-political order, often at the cost of ecological integrity. The resource allocation in *Macbeth* illustrates how the pursuit of power, often unchecked and ruthless, can disregard ecological consequences for the sake of personal ambition¹⁰ (Smith, 2009).

The eco-critical analysis of resource allocation in both narratives sheds light on the intimate connection between power dynamics and environmental exploitation. It underscores how the strategic manipulation of resources, whether in the form of exclusive fishing rights in *Mandaar* or control over land and titles in *Macbeth*, can perpetuate existing social and economic disparities. These manipulations further marginalize already vulnerable communities, rendering

them even more susceptible to the ecological fallout resulting from these power-driven resource allocations¹¹ (Smith, 2009).

In essence, the theme of resource allocation as an instrument of control and dominance, as discerned through eco-criticism in both *Mandaar* and *Macbeth*, underscores the deep-seated link between power dynamics and environmental degradation. It serves as a potent reminder of how the strategic exploitation of resources can exacerbate inequalities and place marginalized communities at the forefront of ecological consequences. These narratives call on us to critically examine and challenge these power-driven resource allocations, advocating for a more equitable and sustainable relationship between humanity and the environment.

Macbeth and Mandaar: Play and Film

In *Macbeth*, the play is set in medieval Scotland and draws inspiration from historical events and figures. It loosely reflects the rule of Lord Macbeth in the eleventh century. Macbeth's hunger for power drives him to commit regicide, resulting in his ascension to the throne. However, his ruthless rule ultimately leads to his downfall and the restoration of order and justice. While there is some historical evidence supporting Macbeth's reign and his demise, William Shakespeare's play takes creative liberties in its portrayal. On the other hand, the fictional scenario of *Mandaar* revolves around a local thug named Dablu bhai, with Mandaar serving as his right-hand man. The comparisons between the characters of Mandaar and Banquo from *Macbeth* become apparent, as they both hold significant positions under their respective leaders. There is a parallel drawn between Dablu bhai's rule in Gailpur and King Duncan's authority in Scotland, with a significant power struggle unfolding.

In both *Macbeth* and the Mandaar scenario, there is a clear focus on the pursuit of power, with characters willing to commit heinous acts to achieve their ambitions. The consequences of unrestrained ambition and the eventual restoration of order are themes common to both narratives. However, it is important to note that while *Macbeth* has a historical foundation with artistic interpretation, the Mandaar scenario exists purely within a fictional context. The connections drawn between the characters and the struggle for power in Mandaar are presented as analogies for the political dynamics seen in *Macbeth*, rather than being based on real historical events. *Macbeth* draws inspiration from historical events in medieval Scotland, while the *Mandaar* scenario is a fictional narrative that uses analogies to convey similar themes of power and political struggles. Both narratives explore the consequences of unchecked ambition but differ in their basis of historical accuracy.

Conclusion

Bengal witnessed a brief period of Diarchy from 1765 AD to 1772 AD under British rule. Interestingly, in the contemporary political landscape of West Bengal, we observe a similar approach to managing illicit activities in specific regions, often with political backing. This resemblance is also noticeable in Geilpur, where a local thug and his right-hand man execute nefarious deeds. Additionally, this individual holds a crucial role in the administration of a legislator from the same region, mirroring the exploitative tactics historically employed by the British in Bengal, profiting from the exploitation of both nature and society.

The British colonial era, marked by oppressive governance, left a lasting impact on Indian leaders and subsequent politicians. This historical backdrop may still influence our society today. Unfortunately, when Muqaddar Mukherjee assumes control of the Geilpur Police Station, he seems disinterested in investigating issues faced by local fishermen or addressing the problems

of unlawful deforestation and overfishing. His posting in Geilpur is a form of punishment, yet he manages to turn it into a lucrative venture, accepting bribes alongside enjoying fried fish.

This scenario resembles the historical kings of Scotland, Duncan and Macbeth, who disregarded the welfare of their people and allowed them to suffer while they exploited nature on a grand scale. In both cases, there is a stark absence of any concern for preserving nature or the well-being of the subjects. Dablu bhai, in his role akin to Duncan, and Mandaar, who resembles Macbeth, displace fishermen from their livelihoods, forcing them into overfishing for personal gain, and even resorting to violence, as seen in the murder of Mokkaï, analogous to the Thane of Cawdor.

Mokkaï becomes the rallying point for the oppressed fishermen, but ultimately, profit prevails over human lives in the eyes of both Dablu bhai and Mandaar. This echoes 'Macbeth,' where the witches concoct a potion using various natural elements, reflecting Macbeth's readiness to manipulate and exploit nature's resources for his own gain, disregarding the consequences. The play is replete with references to unnatural events in the natural world, symbolizing the disruption caused by Macbeth's actions, much like the unsettling atmosphere in Mandaar.

In Act 4, Scene 1 of *Macbeth*, the witches provide a prophecy that Macbeth interprets literally, believing that the forest itself will march against him. This signifies the potential ecological devastation resulting from his actions, a theme that parallels the exploitation occurring in 'Jora-Bheri,' where the privileged position becomes a center for exploitation.

Act 2, Scene 4 of *Macbeth* includes a line by Ross, 'Ah, good father, /Thou seest, the heavens, as troubled with man's act, /Threaten his bloody stage.'¹² These lines highlight the unnatural events in the play, attributing them to the disturbances caused by human actions. This passage suggests

that human deeds can disrupt the balance of the natural world. Similarly, Modon Halder might comment that the weather is no longer in their favor, symbolizing the social, political, and environmental turbulence in Gailpur.

Drawing parallels with *Macbeth*, we see how human actions can disrupt the natural order and lead to ecological and social turmoil. The witches' prophecies in the play, with their unintended consequences, mirror the unexpected repercussions of actions taken in pursuit of personal gain. As we look at the challenges faced by Geilpur and 'Jora-Bheri,' it becomes apparent that the themes explored in literature continue to manifest in our world. Whether it's the exploitation of resources or the disregard for the well-being of communities, these issues persist, demanding our attention and action.

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